

AOX Trade

Intraday Power Trader case study

This case has no right answer. It is one real delivery day of the Dutch power market. We want to see how you think about a complex market under pressure. You are not expected to use every sheet or explore every angle. We are interested in the depth of whichever threads you decide to pull on.

A short primer on the NL power market

You may be very good at other things without having touched power markets before. This section is enough to let you engage with the case. Do not look up anything specific to the day you are given, but feel free to read more about how these markets work generally.

Electricity cannot be stored at scale, so supply and demand must balance continuously. In the Netherlands, trading happens in three sequential stages.

- The day-ahead auction clears one price per 15-minute block the afternoon before delivery. It is the main liquidity event of the market. Participants submit volume-price bids and offers, and a single clearing price is produced per block.
- The intraday continuous market opens after the day-ahead auction and runs until a few minutes before delivery. It is a limit order book per delivery product. Participants use it to adjust positions as new information arrives (weather updates, unit outages, cross-border flow changes, news).
- The imbalance settlement is what TenneT, the Dutch transmission system operator, charges or pays participants at delivery based on whose position contributed to the net system imbalance. The imbalance price is set by the marginal reserve activation and can be extremely volatile. A very short system produces high imbalance prices (sometimes into the thousands of euros per MWh). A very long system produces low or deeply negative prices.

Intraday prices mostly reflect new information relative to what was known at the day-ahead auction. Every intraday move is the market repricing the probability that the system ends up short or long at delivery. As delivery approaches, intraday prices tend to drift toward the expected imbalance settlement.

A trader at a prop firm like ours buys and sells these products to make money on price moves between stages and within the intraday continuous market. The job is a combination of reading fundamentals, reading the order book, and managing risk.

Warm-up question

Q0. Explain the three stages in your own words

Write up how you understand the relationship between the day-ahead auction, the intraday continuous market, and the imbalance settlement. What is each one for? What information does each price contain? If you had never seen this market before, what would surprise you about how they interact?

The day

The attached workbook covers one NL delivery day. Take the time to explore it. Form a view on what happened, where the opportunities were, and what you would have done. **The data is richer than you need, so do not feel obliged to touch every sheet.** We care more about how deeply you pull on the threads you pick than about breadth.

Q1. Tell us the story of the day

Walk us through the fundamentals going into it, what actually happened through the day, and how the three prices (day-ahead, intraday, imbalance) related to each other. There is no required length.

Q2. Where were the biggest opportunities

You pick. By delivery hour, by product, by border, by position size. For each opportunity you name, tell us what made it attractive, when it was first identifiable from the data, and what you would have done with it, including rough sizing, entry level, and when you would have cut. We do not expect more than three or four opportunities to be worth writing up.

Q3. Pick one sheet you found most informative and one you found least

Explain why.

Q4. Take a look at the trades sheet

It is the full continuous trade tape for the delivery day. Is there anything in the micro-structure (price trajectory of specific delivery hours, clustering of executions at particular clock times, anything else) that adds to or contradicts the story you told in Q1? Again, open-ended. If you find nothing worth writing about, say so.

Q5. What did you not have time for

If you had another day, what would you do with it?

How we evaluate

No numeric rubric. We read your submission and score it against these dimensions.

- Can you read a complex market clearly, including parts you have not seen before?
- Do you connect fundamentals to prices, or do you describe them separately?
- When you form a view, does it come with a size, an entry, and an exit, or is it vague?
- Do you notice things you were not asked to notice?
- Are you honest about what you do not know and what you did not get to?

Rules and expectations

- You are not expected to use every sheet, we have given more than you need.
- You may use any tools, including LLMs and the internet. You will walk us through your work in a live session afterwards, so do not submit anything you cannot explain.
- If you think the data has errors or gaps, say so. We may have introduced some intentionally.
- The day this happened has been anonymised.